Cheng Chen

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Education

Tongji University, Shanghai, China — Sept. 2023 – Present
B.Eng. in Electrical Engineering, College of Electronic and Information Engineering
Major Rank: **3/85**

Publications

- Yi Xu*, **Cheng Chen***, Wenzhuo Lei.
  If You Hear It, Help Find It: Orthogonal Knowledge Distillation for Open-Vocabulary Audio-Visual Event Localization
  ACM MM 2026 (Accepted).
- **Cheng Chen***, Yi Xu*, Mufan Cao.
  OrthKD: Extracting Generalized Clinical Knowledge from Heterogeneous Teachers for Lightweight Deployment
  IJCAI 2026 (Accepted).
- **Cheng Chen**, et al.
  Single-pass reliability assessment and risk triage for neural operators
  NeurIPS 2026 Main Track (Under Review; Initial Scores: 4/3/3).
- **Cheng Chen**, et al.
  Rubric-grounded faithfulness evaluation for AI-generated images
  NeurIPS 2026 Evaluations & Datasets Track (Under Review; Initial Scores: 4/4/3).

* equal contribution.

Research Experiences

If You Hear It, Help Find It: Orthogonal Knowledge Distillation for Open-Vocabulary Audio-Visual Event Localization

Accepted at **ACM MM 2026**, Co-first Author

- Addressed modality reliability asymmetry in open-vocabulary audio-visual event localization, where audio is semantically useful but often off-screen, delayed, or noisy, so symmetric distillation lets weak-audio supervision distort temporal boundaries.
- Proposed **OV-OrthKD**, a reliability-aware asymmetric distillation framework: a strong visual teacher supervises decision-aligned features, a weak audio teacher is restricted to an auxiliary orthogonal subspace, and a text prototype anchors open-vocabulary transfer.
- On OV-AVEBench, reached **0.816** segment AP and improved F1@0.5 by **+2.7** points overall and **+3.4** on unseen categories over the official fine-tuning baseline; ablations show weak-audio feature transfer helps only when kept off the decision path.

OrthKD: Extracting Generalized Clinical Knowledge from Heterogeneous Teachers for Lightweight Deployment

Accepted at **IJCAI 2026**, Co-first Author

- Addressed expertise asymmetry in multi-teacher distillation for diabetic retinopathy screening, where a weaker ViT teacher (**0.83 QWK**) harms students under standard logit fusion with a stronger CNN teacher (**0.88 QWK**).
- Proposed **OrthKD**, distilling only complementary feature-level context from the weak teacher while enforcing orthogonality between teacher projections to avoid redundant knowledge transfer.
- Evaluated on **132,049** retinal images; the **5.4M**-parameter MobileNetV3 student reached **0.885 QWK** on EyePACS and improved zero-shot Messidor-2 performance from **0.507** to **0.728 QWK** (**+22.1** percentage points).

Neural-Operator Reliability and Risk Triage

NeurIPS 2026 Main Track, Under Review (4/3/3); First Author

- Studied single-pass reliability assessment for neural operators and selective escalation of unreliable predictions.

Rubric-Grounded Image Faithfulness Evaluation

NeurIPS 2026 Evaluations & Datasets Track, Under Review (4/4/3)

- Studied auditable prompt-faithfulness evaluation for AI-generated images through rubric-level checks.

Awards

- Provincial First Prize, China Robot and Artificial Intelligence Competition (2026), Team Captain
- National 2nd Prize, Global Campus AI Algorithm Elite Competition (2025), Team Captain
- National 3rd Prize, Embedded Chip & System Design Competition, FPGA track (2025), Team Captain

Skills

Programming: Python, PyTorch, Git, Linux, LaTeX, experiment tracking, LLM/agent prototyping.
Foundations: Machine Learning, Data Structures & Algorithms, Linear Algebra, Probability, Optimization, Information Theory, Signal Processing.
Passion: Deep enthusiasm for exploring the unknown and continuous learning across new areas.